

Mapping the Theory of Knowledge: Sources, Justification, and Skepticism

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GRADE LEVEL	DURATION	TOPICS
Grades 11-12 / Intro College	60 minutes	Epistemology

“What exactly do we mean when we say someone “knows” something, and what are the different sources we can even get knowledge from in the first place?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Explain the traditional JTB definition of knowledge and identify the major proposed sources of knowledge: perception, reason, testimony, memory, and introspection.
- Apply the rationalism-versus-empiricism distinction to a specific claim, such as a mathematical truth versus an observational claim, to determine which source(s) of knowledge it depends on.
- Evaluate the internalist and externalist accounts of justification and defend a position on which better explains a specific case of knowledge or its absence.

Materials Needed

- Whiteboard for a “map” of epistemology’s major questions: what is knowledge, what are its sources, what is justification
- Handout with 6-8 short claims to sort by knowledge source (for example, “ $2+2=4$,” “it’s raining outside,” “my grandmother told me our family emigrated in 1920,” “I am currently thinking about pizza”)
- Index cards for the source-sorting activity
- Timer for small-group work

Lesson Procedure

Hook: What Do You “Just Know”?

7 min

Ask students to list three things they claim to “know,” then challenge each: how, specifically, do you know that? Sort the emerging answers loosely on the board into rough categories — saw it, was taught it, figured it out logically, remember it — without yet naming them formally.

Direct Instruction: Mapping the Field

15 min

Introduce epistemology's core questions — what is knowledge, where does it come from, what justifies belief — and the traditional JTB starting point. Present the major proposed sources of knowledge: perception, reason or a priori intuition, testimony, memory, and introspection, noting that these sources often overlap rather than operating in isolation.

Small-Group Activity: Sorting and the Rationalism/Empiricism Divide

18 min

Groups sort the provided claims by which knowledge source(s) they seem to depend on, then use this sorting to introduce the rationalism-empiricism debate: can some knowledge, like mathematics or logic, be gained by reason alone, independent of experience, or does even that knowledge ultimately trace back to experience? Groups pick their hardest-to-classify claim and prepare a one-minute defense of their classification.

Direct Instruction and Discussion: Internalism vs. Externalism

14 min

Introduce the justification debate: internalism (justification depends on factors internally accessible to the believer, like their reasons and evidence) versus externalism (justification can depend on external factors the believer isn't aware of, like whether their belief-forming process is reliable), using a case where someone has a perfectly reliable but unrecognized ability to detect true statements. Ask which view better explains whether that person's beliefs count as knowledge.

Closure

6 min

Exit ticket: students pick one "known" claim from the opening hook and identify its source and which justification framework — internalist or externalist — best explains why it counts as knowledge.

Discussion Questions

- 1 Are perception, reason, testimony, memory, and introspection genuinely distinct sources of knowledge, or do they overlap so much — since testimony often ultimately rests on someone else's perception or reasoning — that the categories break down?
- 2 Can any knowledge really be gained by reason alone, independent of all experience, as rationalists claim for mathematics and logic, or does even seemingly a priori knowledge depend on some experiential input to acquire the relevant concepts?
- 3 If someone forms true beliefs through a reliable process they're totally unaware of, do they really "know" the resulting claims, even though they couldn't justify them if challenged?
- 4 How much of what you "know" actually rests on testimony rather than on your own direct perception or reasoning — and does that change how careful you should be about trusting your sources?
- 5 Is the traditional JTB starting point still a good baseline for thinking about knowledge, or does treating it as obviously correct risk skipping past its real weaknesses?

Assessment

Students pick one claim they personally believe they "know" and write a short structured analysis identifying its source or sources of knowledge and explaining whether an internalist or externalist account of justification better explains why it counts as knowledge. Grade on correct use of the vocabulary from class and coherence of the analysis, not the specific claim chosen.

Extension Activity

Have students interview a family member or friend about how they "know" something they hold to be true — a family history claim, a practical skill, a belief about the world — and write a short reflection classifying the knowledge source(s) involved and any epistemic weaknesses in the chain, such as unreliable testimony or faded memory.

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